StockPilot — Investor Meeting Prep

A printable workbook for walking into your first investor meeting prepared, defensible, and confident.

Last updated: 2026-05-22

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How to use this document

Read it once cover-to-cover before the meeting. Then fill in the highlighted blanks (_____) with your specific numbers. Practice the answers out loud — every key answer should fit in 30 seconds.

The last page is a tear-off cheat sheet to bring with you.

Part 1 — Decide your funding path

The shape of your pitch changes radically depending on what you're raising for. Pick ONE before you walk in.

Path	Round size	What the money buys	Your pitch in one line
A. Bootstrap / friends & angels	$25k – $250k	6–9 months part-time dev, light onboarding of 2-3 design-partner orgs	"Look what I've built with almost nothing — help me prove it works for more customers."
B. Pre-seed / seed VC	$500k – $1.5M	1–2 engineering hires, 1 sales hire, 18 months runway, multi-tenant SaaS pivot	"We have a working product, a real customer, and a clear path to vertical SaaS."
C. Strategic / channel	Variable	Charter-network rollout, district-level deal, partnership with parent organization	"We've already solved this for one org — let's blanket all 8,000 charter schools."
D. Customer expansion (light)	$50k – $150k	3–5 more charter orgs as paying customers, keep founder-led	"L4L Fresno is paying for the product. I want 4 more like them."

Action: circle the path you're on: A / B / C / D

If you're not sure, **default to D for the first meeting**. It's the most defensible (you already have a customer and a working product) and lets you avoid making promises about scale you haven't tested.

Your specific path: A → B

You've told me you're pursuing **paths A and B** — start with friends-and-angels for $50k–$250k to prove the model with 2–3 more customers, then go to seed VCs for $750k–$1.5M once the second customer is paying. This is the right sequence. Specifically:

Meeting 1 (this one) — likely angels / friends. Frame it as path A. Round size: **$150k–$250k**, valuation **$2M–$3M post-money**. Use of funds: keep building, onboard 2 charter design-partners, get to "two paying customers" milestone.

Meeting 6–10 months from now — seed VCs. Frame it as path B. Round size: **$750k–$1.5M**, valuation **$5M–$8M post-money** (your traction by then determines the upper bound). Use of funds:

first engineering hire, sales lead, scale GTM.

Don’t pitch path B numbers in a path A meeting. You’ll spook smaller-check investors who write $25k–$100k checks and want to see milestones before bigger players come in. Save the seed-round language for when you actually have the milestones.

Part 2 — Your numbers

You will be asked, point-blank: *"How much are you raising and at what valuation?"* Have the answer ready.

2.1 How much to ask for

Don't pick a number from thin air. Build it from the math.

Step 1 — Monthly burn (write your numbers in):

Line item	Monthly
Your salary	$ _______
Co-founder / manager salary (if applicable)	$ _______
Engineering hire (mid-level)	$11,000
Sales / customer-success hire	$8,000
Marketing / events	$1,500
Software / tools / accounting	$1,000
Legal reserve	$500
Infrastructure (Vercel + Supabase + Resend + Gemini)	$100
Subtotal	$ _______
× 1.3 for taxes & benefits	$ _______
= Total monthly burn	$ _______

Step 2 — Multiply by 18 months for runway, then add 20% safety buffer:

> *Total ask = monthly burn × 18 × 1.2 = $ _______*

Step 3 — Round to the nearest $50k. That's your number.

Sanity check: if your number is under $250k or over $2M for a first round, double-check. Pre-seed sweet spot is usually **$500k – $1M** for a working product with a real customer.

2.2 Valuation — what's the company "worth"?

For pre-seed with a working product and one paying customer, **post-money valuations of $3M – $6M** are normal in 2026.

Formula investors use: - Round / (post-money valuation) = % equity given up - $500k raise at $5M post-money = 10% sold - $750k raise at $5M post-money = 15% sold - $1M raise at $6M post-money = ~17% sold

Healthy target: give up 10–18% of the company in your first real round. Less than 10% and investors think you're greedy. More than 20–25% and you're selling too much too early.

My fill-in number for this meeting: - Round size: $ _______ - Post-money valuation: $ _______ - % equity sold: _______ %

2.3 Use of funds (one-slide breakdown)

Investors want to see exactly where their dollar goes. Example for a $750k raise:

Bucket	$	%
Engineering (1 senior + 0.5 founder time)	$400k	53%
Sales / customer success (1 hire, year 1)	$150k	20%
Marketing + design partners	$75k	10%
Legal, accounting, ops	$50k	7%
Infrastructure & tools	$25k	3%
Reserve (12% buffer)	$50k	7%
Total	**$750k**	**100%**

Your version (fill in):

Bucket	**$**	**%**
Engineering	$ _______	_____ %
Sales / customer success	$ _______	_____ %
Marketing	$ _______	_____ %
Legal / accounting / ops	$ _______	_____ %
Infrastructure	$ _______	_____ %
Reserve	$ _______	_____ %
Total	**$** _______	100%

Part 3 — Co-founder / manager equity

This conversation kills more startup friendships than any other. Have it *before* an investor asks. Put the result on paper, signed, before the meeting.

3.1 What role is your manager actually playing?

Be honest with yourself. The honest answer dictates the equity range.

Their commitment	Equity range	What it means
Full-time co-founder. Quitting/quit their job, taking founder salary, on the cap table.	30 – 50%	Real co-founder. 4-year vest with 1-year cliff. On all major decisions.
Part-time co-founder. Keeping their job for now but committing 15+ hrs/week. Equity earned via vesting.	10 – 25%	Becomes full equity only if they go full-time later.
Domain advisor. A few hours/month of warehouse expertise + intros. Keeps day job indefinitely.	0.5 – 2%	Advisor role. Standard 2-year vest. Not on the cap table as a founder.
Future Head of Operations. Joins as employee #1 after the raise.	1 – 5%	Standard early-employee grant.

Honest check: would they still want this role if there was no equity, just a fair consulting fee? - **Yes** → advisor or future employee, 0.5–5%. - **No, they want skin in the game** → real co-founder, 10–50% depending on commitment level.

Your specific situation

Based on what you've told me: your manager has 10+ years in warehousing, he's defining what features to build and how each should work, you implement them. He's keeping his day job. He's not on payroll.

That's a domain-expert co-founder — meaningful equity but not 50/50. Specifically:

If he commits…	Reasonable equity	Notes
5–10 hrs/week ongoing, regular cadence, named “co-founder” publicly	**10–15%**	This is most likely your situation. Real co-founder title, real product input, but not the operational risk-taker.
15+ hrs/week, eventually joining full-time after seed	**15–25%**	Higher because he’s likely to go full-time. Vest aggressively so unvested returns if he doesn’t.
1–3 hrs/week, occasional advice	**2–5%**	Advisor role, not co-founder. Use the standard FAST advisor agreement template.
Just “lending the name” / introductions only	**0.5–1%**	Advisor, no formal title.

My recommended starting offer for your conversation: 12% equity, 4-year vest, 1-year cliff, “Co-founder / Head of Operations” title.

The math behind this: - You did 100% of the build. You take the technical risk going forward. Default founder share for the builder: 50–70%. - He brings irreplaceable domain expertise — without his feature direction the product wouldn’t fit a real warehouse. Worth real equity. - He hasn’t quit his job. He’s not taking the financial risk you are. That’s why the number is 12% and not 30%. - 4-year vest with 1-year cliff means: if he disengages in year 1, none of it transfers. After year 1, he owns 3% and earns 0.25% per month for the next 36 months. Protects both of you.

Your specific numbers (fill in):

- Manager’s name: ____
- Title: Co-founder / Head of Operations (recommended)
- Equity: **12%** (or adjust per his actual time commitment)
- Vest: **4 years, 1-year cliff** (non-negotiable)
- Acceleration: single-trigger on acquisition (he gets 50% of unvested if you’re bought)

Important for the investor meeting: investors don’t care that you gave him 12% vs 8% vs 20%. They DO care that: 1. The agreement is in writing before they invest. 2. There’s a vest schedule that protects the company. 3. Your remaining equity is enough to keep you motivated for 6+ years.

A clean 88% / 12% / future 10% for the option pool = you keep 78% post-pool. That’s healthy. Anything where you end up with under 50% before raising looks weak.

3.2 The conversation script

Have this conversation BEFORE the investor meeting. Word-for-word starter:

> *"I'm going into investor meetings soon and they're going to ask about our cap table. I want to get this clean and fair between us before anyone else weighs in. Here's how I'm thinking about it: [your number]% equity for you, with a 4-year vesting schedule and a 1-year cliff. That means you earn the equity over 4 years of work, and if either of us leaves in the first year, the leaver gets nothing. After year 1, you'd own [25% of your number]% and keep earning the rest each month for 3 more years. Does that feel right to you? Let's get something on paper this week."*

Three things to nail down before the investor meeting:

1. **Equity percentage** (above)
2. **Vesting schedule** (4-year vest, 1-year cliff is standard)
3. **What happens if one of you leaves** (vested equity stays with leaver, unvested returns to the pool)

Cost to get this right with a lawyer: $500 – $2,000. Cheapest insurance you will ever buy.

Part 4 — What makes StockPilot different (memorize these six)

These are your differentiation talking points. Memorize them. Be able to say each in under 20 seconds.

1. **“5 to 500 times cheaper than commercial WMS at every team size, every year, forever.”** No per-user fees. Run a 500-person warehouse for $3k/year instead of $1.5M/year.
2. **“AI features that no commercial WMS bundles.”** AI Shelf Scan — one phone photo counts a whole shelf in 8 seconds. AI Inventory Assistant — natural-language chat grounded in real DB queries; cannot hallucinate quantities. AI PO Import — paste a vendor invoice, get a draft PO automatically.
3. **“Mobile-first, not mobile-as-afterthought.”** Native iOS + Android apps. Most commercial WMS mobile is a webview of a 2008-era desktop UI.
4. **“Real-time across devices.”** Sub-250ms updates via WebSockets when a phone scanner records a count. Commercial WMS polls.
5. **“No-account public order link.”** External requesters submit orders via a single URL — no seat license, no training. Commercial WMS would charge per-requester.
6. **“Modern stack, no vendor lock-in.”** Vercel + Supabase + Postgres + React. Open standards. The customer owns their data and can hire any dev to maintain it.

Part 5 — "How does this change the game?"

This is the *narrative* — the story that makes investors lean forward. Don't list features. Paint contrast.

The before/after story

Before: A 20-person warehouse uses spreadsheets, paper, and email. The manager spends Friday afternoons reconciling counts that don't match. Cycle counts take 4 staff × 6 hours every quarter. A teacher who needs 30 textbooks emails three times before someone confirms the order. Buying NetSuite WMS to fix all this costs $50k year one, $36k/year forever, 6-month implementation, two weeks of staff training, and locks them into Oracle's ecosystem.

After (StockPilot): Day-one deployment. Annual cost: under $1,500. Teacher fills a form, order lands in the queue, picker scans on their phone, manager sees real-time progress, signature captured at delivery. Quarterly cycle count: 24 hours becomes 90 minutes via AI shelf-scan. Every dollar that would have gone to Oracle stays in the org's actual mission.

The headline line

> ***"We give organizations enterprise warehouse software at vending-machine prices, with AI no incumbent ships."***

Why now?

- Vercel + Supabase made deploying production infrastructure ~50× cheaper than 2020.
- Gemini Flash AI inference costs ~$0.0001 per request — shelf-scan is finally economical.
- Charter schools (8,000+ in US) and similar mid-market orgs have been priced out of every commercial WMS — they're using Excel, and they hate it.

> ***"Two years ago this would have been a $5 million startup. Today it's a one-founder + one-domain-expert build, and the cost advantage is the moat."***

Part 6 — Tough questions + your prepared answers

Investors will ask these. Have a 30-second answer ready for each.

Q1. “How big is this market?”

> *“US warehouse software market is about $5 billion. The SMB / mid-market vertical — orgs under 500 people who are currently using Excel or spreadsheets — is a $1.5 billion subset that’s underserved. Our wedge is charter schools specifically: 8,000+ orgs nationwide, about $200 million addressable. We’ve validated one; we want to land 50 in the next 24 months.”*

Q2. “Why hasn’t NetSuite / Cin7 / [incumbent] already done this?”

> *“Two reasons. First, their cost structure — sales teams, account managers, legacy compute — requires per-user pricing. Even if they wanted to copy us, they’d cannibalize their own revenue. Second, our AI features depend on serverless inference costs that became economical in the last 18 months. Incumbents’ architecture predates that curve.”*

Q3. “Why you? Why now?”

> *“I built this and operate it daily for our anchor customer. My co-founder brings 15+ years of warehouse operations experience [adjust to your manager’s actual experience]. We have a working product, paying customer, real ops feedback loop. Two years ago this would have been a $5M startup. Today, with Vercel + Supabase + cheap inference, it’s shippable by two people. We have an 18-month window before bigger players notice.”*

Q4. “What are your unit economics?”

> *“At $500 per month per organization: gross margin around 95%, since infrastructure cost per customer is around $25/month at low scale. Target customer acquisition cost: under $5k. Sweet-spot annual contract value: $5k–$15k. We expect 14-month payback at the entry tier and 8-month payback once we land district-level deals.”*

Q5. “What if your manager / co-founder leaves?”

> *“We have a 4-year vesting schedule with a 1-year cliff in writing. If they leave in year one, their equity returns to the pool. Beyond that, we’re documenting the operational knowledge as we go — every workflow lives in our Procedures module, which we built specifically to codify domain expertise. Risk is real but it’s mitigated.”*

Q6. “You have one customer. Where’s the customer concentration risk?”

> *“L4L Fresno is our design partner — we’re using them to harden the product. We have three additional charter orgs in late-stage conversations and expect to sign one as a paying customer this quarter. Our 18-month plan is to get to ten paying customers, none representing more than 20% of revenue.” (Build that pipeline before the meeting if you can.)*

Q7. “What’s the exit?”

> *“Two paths we’ve thought about. First, strategic acquisition by a larger WMS — NetSuite, Manhattan, Cin7 — at $20M–$200M in years 4–6 when we’ve proven vertical depth. Second, organic growth into a vertical-SaaS rollup for education and similar mid-market orgs at $100M+ ARR. We’re not optimizing for exit; we’re optimizing for product-market fit. But both paths are open.”*

Q8. “What if AI gets commoditized?”

> *“We don’t sell AI — we sell the integration. Shelf-scan works because of the schema we built, the pick-route optimization, the audit trail. If AI inference goes to zero, our margins improve. If it stays expensive, we keep the lead because we built around the cost curve. Either way, AI is one feature in a system; it’s not the moat.”*

Q9. “How will you sell this?”

> *“Three channels. First, charter-school management organizations (CMOs) — they oversee multiple schools and can deploy us across all of them in one deal. Second, education conferences — direct booth presence at events like NCSC and the Charter School conference. Third, word of mouth — once one CMO has us, peer CMOs follow.”*

Q10. “What’s your biggest risk?”

> *“Speed to product-market fit. We have one strong customer and a working product, but vertical SaaS only works if we can land 5–10 more customers in 12 months and prove the workflow generalizes. If we can’t, we have a great custom system for one org but not a venture-scale business. The first $500k is specifically about closing that gap.” (Being honest about risk earns investor trust. Pretending you have none kills trust.)*

Part 7 — Things to NOT say

These statements signal naïveté and tank meetings. Cross them off your mental list.

- “We don’t really have competitors.” Every product has competitors.
- “We’re going to do everything.” Pick one wedge.
- “It’s basically done.” Investors fund growth, not completion.
- “I need the money to pay myself.” Frame as “extend runway / hire engineering.”
- “My friend says it’s worth $5M.” Valuation comes from market, not opinion.
- Any number you can’t defend with arithmetic.
- “We just need to be acquired.” Investors fund growth stories, not exits.
- Trash-talking competitors. Specific comparison is fine; contempt isn’t.

Part 8 — Demo script

You have a working product. **Use it.** A 5-minute demo separates you from 95% of pitches investors see.

Order of operations (practice this exact sequence)

1. **(30 sec)** Open the dashboard. *“This is the warehouse manager’s morning view. You can see what’s pending, what’s overdue, today’s activity.”*
2. **(60 sec)** Click into an order. *“A teacher submitted this via our no-account public link — they didn’t need to log in. The manager approves it, the system reserves stock automatically, and a picker on the floor sees it on their phone.”*
3. **(45 sec)** Demo the AI shelf-scan on a phone if possible (or a recorded clip if not). *“Watch — one photo, eight seconds, the system identifies every textbook on the shelf and updates inventory. This used to take 20 minutes of manual counting.”*
4. **(45 sec)** Open the AI inventory assistant. Ask it a real question like *“how many Chromebooks do we have?”* — it answers from the live database. *“Notice how it shows which tool it called. We literally cannot hallucinate numbers — every answer comes from a real SQL query against their inventory.”*
5. **(30 sec)** Click into a PDF — packing slip or pick slip. *“Item photos inline. Org-local timezone. Looks like a Fortune 500 logistics doc, not a 2008 WMS printout.”*
6. **(30 sec)** Close it out. *“We did all of that with no per-user fees, no implementation cost, no 6-month onboarding. The cost to run this for our customer is about $80 a month.”*

Total: ~4 minutes. Leaves room for questions.

Demo failure mode

If the wifi dies or something breaks, **don’t panic**. Pull up a screen recording on your phone (record one beforehand) and narrate. Investors care that you’re calm under pressure more than they care that the demo runs perfectly.

Part 9 — What to bring

Required:

- **One-pager** — single sheet of paper. Front: what you do, who it's for, traction, ask. Back: 3 charts (cost vs. competition, growth plan, team).
- **10-slide deck** (PDF on a thumb drive AND a hosted link):
  1. Problem
  2. Solution (with screenshot)
  3. Market size
  4. Product (with screenshot)
  5. Traction (L4L Fresno + pipeline)
  6. Business model + unit economics
  7. Competition (incumbents + cost comparison)
  8. Team (you + manager + advisors)
  9. The ask + use of funds
  10. Vision (where this is in 5 years)
- **Live demo** of the actual product.

Nice to have:

- Financial model (3-year projection, in Excel or Google Sheets).
- Customer reference letter from L4L Fresno (one paragraph, signed).
- This printable prep document, in your bag for last-minute review.

Part 10 — Pre-meeting checklist (24 hours before)

- ☐ Equity agreement with manager signed and filed.
- ☐ Round size, valuation, and use-of-funds memorized.
- ☐ Demo rehearsed at least 3 times, with a phone backup recording.
- ☐ 30-second answers memorized for all 10 tough questions.
- ☐ Three pieces of “ammunition” ready:
  - The 5-500× cost comparison table.
  - The AI shelf-scan time savings (20 min → 30 sec).
  - Pipeline number (how many other charter orgs you’re talking to).
- ☐ Dress one notch above what you think you should wear.
- ☐ Arrive 10 minutes early. Use the bathroom. Drink water. Don’t drink coffee within an hour of the meeting — jitters read as nervousness.
- ☐ Have a question ready for THEM. “What’s your investment thesis around vertical SaaS?” or “What’s your typical check size at pre-seed?” Investors want to feel evaluated too.

Part 11 — Post-meeting follow-up

Within 24 hours, send a thank-you email:

> *Subject: StockPilot — thanks for the time today*
>
> *[Investor first name],*
>
> *Thank you for meeting today. I appreciated your questions on [specific topic they pushed on, e.g. "the customer concentration risk" or "the sales channel strategy"]. Here are the materials we discussed:*
>
> - *One-pager: [link]*
> - *Deck: [link]*
> - *Cost comparison analysis: [link]*
>
> *If it would be useful, I'm happy to set up a 15-minute reference call with [customer name at L4L Fresno].*
>
> *Next steps from my end: [one concrete thing they asked for, e.g. "I'll send you the updated pipeline numbers by Friday."]*
>
> *Best, [Your name]*

Three rules: 1. Send within 24 hours. 2. Reference something specific from the conversation (proves you listened). 3. Have a concrete next step.

If they don't respond within a week, send ONE polite follow-up. After that, let it go. Founders who chase look desperate.

TEAR-OFF CHEAT SHEET

Print this last page and bring it to the meeting.

MY ASK

- Round size: $ _______
- Post-money valuation: $ _______
- Equity sold: _____ %
- Runway: _____ months

MY CO-FOUNDER

- Name: _____________________
- Equity: _____ %
- Vesting: 4-year / 1-year cliff
- Role: _____________________

THE THREE NUMBERS THAT WIN THE MEETING

1. We cost $1,000/year. NetSuite WMS costs $50,000/year. Same workflows.
2. Quarterly cycle count: 24 hours → 90 minutes with AI shelf-scan.
3. We have 1 paying customer + ____ in pipeline.

THE HEADLINE LINE

> *"We give organizations enterprise warehouse software at vending-machine prices, with AI no incumbent ships."*

IF THEY ASK SOMETHING I DON'T KNOW

> *“Great question. I want to give you a real answer, not a made-up one. Let me follow up with the exact number tomorrow.”*

This is a strength, not a weakness. Founders who bullshit get caught. Founders who say “let me get back to you” with the answer in 24 hours look credible.

MY ONE QUESTION BACK TO THEM

End of prep document. Good luck.